Claude Effort Levels — *cheat sheet*

Claude Code slider → API value → cost, anchored to **bkit** agents
Rates verified against platform.claude.com · **August 2026**

POSITION 1	POSITION 2	POSITION 3	POSITION 4	POSITION 5	POSITION 6
Low	**Medium**	**High** DEFAULT	**Extra**	**Max** SESSION	**Ultracode** SESSION
`low`	`medium`	`high`	`xhigh`	`max`	`xhigh`
Persists across sessions	Persists across sessions	Default on every model except Opus 4.7	Default on Opus 4.7. App label is "Extra", not "Extra high"	Rejected by settings file; env var only	**Not a deeper level.** Sends `xhigh` — less than Max — plus multi-agent workflow orchestration

EFFORT	API	BEST FOR — ANCHORED TO THE BKIT AGENTS THAT USE IT	OUT TOKENS*	COST/CALL	VS OPUS HIGH†
CLAUDE OPUS 5		$5 / $25 per MTok · 1M context · 128K max out			
Low	`low`	**bkit: never.** All five `*-summary` agents run Low on Haiku 4.5 instead. If it's simple enough for Low, drop the model too	~1.5K	**$0.088**	0.35×
Medium	`medium`	`bkit-plan-review-2`, `bkit-plan-scope-check-1` — judgement without exploration. *You:* sanity-check a plan, review a short diff	~4K	**$0.150**	0.6×
High	`high`	`bkit-build-challenge-1/2`, `bkit-build-plan-verify`, `bkit-utility-audit-*` — finding what's wrong with what exists. *You:* review a diff, debug red CI	~8K	**$0.250**	1×
Extra	`xhigh`	`bkit-plan-generate`, `bkit-design-generate`, `bkit-debug-failure-diagnose` — authoring what everything downstream depends on. *You:* architecture calls, root-cause after two failed attempts	~25K	**$0.675**	2.7×
Max	`max`	**bkit: never** — zero of 48 agents. *You:* one correctness-critical problem where being wrong beats 6× the spend	~60K	**$1.550**	**6.2×**
Ultracode	`xhigh` ×N	**bkit: can't** — frontmatter rejects it. *You:* codebase-wide sweep, 500-file migration, multi-lens review with adversarial verification	~25K /agent	**~$10**[2]	**~40×**
CLAUDE SONNET 5		$3 / $15 per MTok · intro $2 / $10 until 31 Aug 2026 · 1M context			
Low	`low`	**bkit: never** — Haiku 4.5 owns this tier. *You:* high-volume, latency-sensitive chat	~1.5K	**$0.053**	0.21×
Medium	`medium`	`bkit-build-plan-execute`, `bkit-debug-failure-remediate`, `bkit-ship-conflict-resolve`, `bkit-utility-update-*` — the entire execution tier. *You:* implement a change you've already spec'd, write tests, sync docs	~4K	**$0.090**	0.36×
High	`high`	**bkit: never** — it jumps Sonnet/medium straight to Opus/high. *You:* general coding wanting more than Medium without Opus money	~8K	**$0.150**	0.6×
Extra	`xhigh`	**Rarely right.** Costs more than Opus 5 at High ($0.250), which is also stronger. Move model, not effort	~25K	**$0.405**	1.6×
Max	`max`	**Almost never.** Costs more than Opus 5 at Extra ($0.675)	~60K	**$0.930**	3.7×
Ultracode	`xhigh` ×N	Same fan-out work as Opus Ultracode, cheaper per agent	~25K /agent	**~$6**[2]	**~24×**

THE TWO CROSSOVERS TO MEMORISE

Sonnet 5 at Extra ($0.405) costs more than Opus 5 at High ($0.250) — and Opus is the stronger model.

Sonnet 5 at Max ($0.930) costs more than Opus 5 at Extra ($0.675).

Past Sonnet/High, **change model, not effort**. That is exactly the jump bkit already makes — Sonnet/medium straight to Opus/high, with nothing in between.

Going up a model tier costs 1.67× (Sonnet→Opus) or 2× (Opus→Fable). Going High→Max costs ~6×.

WHAT BKIT ACTUALLY USES — 5 PAIRINGS

Haiku 4.5 · low	the five `*-summary` agents
Sonnet 5 · medium	the whole execution tier (~17 agents)
Opus 5 · medium	`plan-review-2`, `plan-scope-check-1`
Opus 5 · high	review, verify, audit, ship
Opus 5 · xhigh	generate, update, diagnose, reconcile

Never `max`. Zero of 48 agents. The split is *decide* vs *do*: pay for the decision, economise on the execution.

Frontmatter `effort` overrides the session slider — so bkit is unaffected by wherever you leave it. Only `CLAUDE_CODE_EFFORT_LEVEL` outranks it; leave that unset.

FINE PRINT

***** Output-token figures are an **estimate** — Anthropic publishes no per-level token counts (effort is "a behavioral signal, not a strict token budget"). Costs are exact arithmetic on that estimate, at 10,000 input tokens per call.

† Cross-model rows are a **cost ruler, not a capability equivalence**: "the effort scale is calibrated per model, so the same level name does not represent the same underlying value across models." Within a model the ordering is sound.

[2] Ultracode cost assumes a 15-agent workflow. Hard caps: ~16 concurrent, 1000 per workflow lifetime.

Ultracode: session-only. Enable with `/effort ultracode`, `claude --effort ultracode` (needs v2.1.203+), or the keyword "ultracode" in a prompt for one turn. Silently degrades to plain `xhigh` if workflows are off.

Thinking is a separate toggle from Effort. On Opus 5, keep Thinking on and lower Effort rather than switching it off — thinking-on at Low beats thinking-off at similar cost.